

51 Ivy League Offers Later: The Man Changing How India Competes for the World's Best Universities

In a sector long defined by shortcuts and inflated promises, Kunal Mehra has built something rare: a premium, outcome-driven institution quietly shaping how India's most ambitious students reach the world's most selective universities. Crimson Education entered the Indian market in 2020 and in FY25 has crossed the INR 100 crore mark, making it India's most successful elite education consultant.

When Kunal Mehra, CEO & Managing Director at Crimson Education India & MENA brought Crimson Education to India in 2020, the premium admissions consulting market was fragmented, informal, and in many corners not entirely honest. "The great Indian 'jugaad' around admissions was everywhere," he recalls. "Padded profiles. Too-good-to-be-true projects. Stories that belonged to nobody." What was absent was an institution capable of competing with the best admissions advisory operations in the world while being genuinely rooted in the Indian context. That is what he set out to build.

Crimson Education is not a counseling agency in the conventional sense. Founded in 2013, it is today a US\$1 billion global education network in over 30 countries, with 2,400-plus experts including Former Admissions Officers from the Ivy League and Oxbridge. Every student works with a Strategist, a Capstone Mentor, an Extracurriculars Expert and an Essay Mentor: a team-based model matched by proprietary technology and adapted, under Mehra's watch, to the specific dynamics of Indian families, where education is rarely a solo decision and parents are key stakeholders. The results from India's 2026 admissions cycle: 51 Ivy League offers, 186-plus admits to Top 20 US universities, with Crimson's admit rates running 5-7x the general pool at Harvard, Yale, Columbia, Stanford, and MIT.

Navigating a Volatile Landscape

The past year tested everyone in this space. The 2025-26 cycle was the most competitive on record: Columbia's acceptance rate fell to 4.23%, Yale's to 4.24%, with several Ivies declining to publish



Kunal Mehra
CEO & Regional Director
at Crimson Education India & MENA

figures at all. Simultaneously, the Trump administration revoked Harvard's certification to enrol international students in May 2025; courts blocked the move twice. Columbia settled for \$220 million in July to restore frozen federal funding. Penn reached its own agreement. Harvard has continued to fight in court and as of April 2026, district court rulings have largely favoured universities.

For Indian families, the anxiety has been real. Mehra's response has been measured: "It's important to separate rhetoric from structural reality. International students contribute over \$43 billion annually to the US economy. The courts have repeatedly agreed the mechanisms used to target them were unlawful." The pipeline held, and the Class of 2030 cycle proved it.

What Real Preparation Looks Like

Crimson's Co-Founder & CEO, Jamie Beaton was quoted in the Wall Street Journal this May on how schools now use early decision rounds, waitlists,

and likely letters as yield management tools, and how reading those signals has become as important as the application itself. That institutional intelligence, applied to the Indian context by Mehra's team, is a large part of what separates Crimson from the market around it.

The deeper differentiator, though, is time. Crimson India's one-of-a-kind foundational programme for Grades 6 to 8 reflects Mehra's central conviction: the application is only a record of what a student has already built. Students in recent cycles have created legal support platforms for abuse survivors, designed rural health technology, and published original research, work that reflects genuine curiosity. A Crimson student in this admission cycle also received the *Pradhan Mantri Rashtriya Bal Puraskar* for her research in neurodegenerative diseases like Parkinson's. On AI-generated applications, Mehra is unequivocal: "Authenticity is currency today. AI can't tell us what excites you or what you want to change in the world."

Geographically, Mehra has extended Crimson India well beyond the metros. Three full-ride Ivy League admits came from non-metro cities like Raipur and Jaipur this cycle alone, betting early on a shift he describes simply: "The mindset is moving from just 'going abroad' to going with purpose."

Six years in, what he has built is an institution that operates in two registers simultaneously: the granular tactical and the long developmental arc, and does both with a consistency that the market around him is only now beginning to understand.